

City faces \$48.4m deficit

Boston officials cite storm costs, police overtime

By Niki Griswold
GLOBE STAFF

In a sign of growing financial pressure, the city of Boston is facing a nearly \$50 million budget deficit to close the fiscal year that ends in June, a gap the city may cover by dipping into its reserve funds, officials said Monday.

Ashley Groffenberger, the city's chief financial officer, said the \$48.4 million deficit is being driven by higher-than-anticipated spending on snow removal, police overtime, and employee health insurance. She said the deficit is unrelated to ongoing budget challenges in the Boston Public Schools, where officials separately approved a budget that will cut 300 to 400 positions.

City officials have been raising the alarm for months about a coming budget crunch. Mayor Michelle Wu told department heads in December to propose how they would cut 2 percent of their budgets and ordered city staff to immediately delay and control hiring. And earlier this month, the administration limited or froze spending on food, travel, and other expenses.

The \$48.4 million deficit amounts to roughly 1 percent of BUDGET, Page A5

Plowed under

The barrage of snowstorms battered municipal budgets. **B1.**

As budget ax drops, questions come up

Teachers take brunt of job loss

By John Hilliard and Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

As Boston Public Schools grapple with a budget crunch, city officials have proposed far more cuts for teachers and classroom aides than for higher-paid administrators in the central office.

Yet it is precisely those administrators whose ranks have ballooned in recent years.

A Globe analysis of staffing data found that Boston schools nearly doubled the size of its bureaucracy over the past decade, hiring staff who do not work in classrooms as federal money poured in to tackle growing student needs because of the pandemic.

The hiring surge came as enrollment rapidly fell.

With up to 300 classroom jobs now on the chopping block, some parents and education advocates warn that the disproportionate focus on teachers and aides will harm children. Critics worry if Boston schools couldn't fix its most stubborn challenges while awash in nearly a half-billion dollars in pandemic aid, the problems will only get worse after budget woes — particularly if cuts aren't focused on keeping the strongest teachers.

Mayor Michelle Wu's administration has defended the staff SCHOOLS, Page A5

A LOSING BET

CHINATOWN'S HIDDEN CASINOS

PARLORS CAN RUIN LIVES. THEY'RE ALSO ILLEGAL AND UNRESTRAINED.



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

BY DANNY MCDONALD AND CHRIS SERRES | GLOBE STAFF
MABLE CHAN | GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

As the rain pelted down in thick sheets one day last spring, filling the narrow alleyways of Boston's Chinatown with shin-high water, Natalie Truong cautiously approached a four-story brownstone on Harrison Avenue.

Wearing rubber boots and clutching an umbrella, Truong peered through the bars of a rusted metal gate that guarded a darkened stairwell. She knew where those stairs ended: a third-floor gambling den packed with slot machines and green-felt mahjong tables. From the front steps, she could hear the distinctive clicking of the ivory mahjong tiles — a sound that transported her back to her childhood — and could smell the pungent odor of cigarette smoke. She hoped she'd find her father here.

Days earlier, he had abruptly canceled an important medical appointment and had stopped responding to Truong's many phone calls and text messages.

阅读简体中文版



Read in simplified Chinese

She knew what silence usually meant.

This brownstone was one of his haunts, among the many where she'd found him in the past, gambling away. He might be here, or in one of the dozens of Chinatown's illicit gambling dens where, she said, he has over the last 30 years spent countless hours at illegal slot machines, spending every last remaining cent of his fixed income. If not for Truong's help managing his finances, bills might never get paid, she said. She worries the money would simply disappear into the slots.

Truong's father has no shortage of places to go when he succumbs to what she considers a gambling addiction — a "festering wound," she said, for many in Chinatown.

"But no one wants to talk about it," she said, "or even admit it."

Truong started to climb the stairs.

CHINATOWN, Page A6

Natalie Truong visited the basement of a parlor on Oxford Street in Chinatown where she had before found her father gambling.

Brazen invasion of mansion

Intruder pistol-whipped caretaker, grabbed valuables, and fled in stolen Porsche, says owner of Beverly estate

By Emily Sweeney and Lea Skene
GLOBE STAFF

BEVERLY — The 911 call described a gun-wielding intruder who assaulted the home's caretaker and searched the sprawling mansion for family valuables before fleeing in a stolen Porsche.

Who did it remains a mystery, unfolding in a particularly affluent corner of this picturesque seaside community, known as Prides Crossing.

The setting is a \$20 million waterfront mansion known as "Rock Edge," a historic North Shore property perched atop a bluff overlooking the ocean. Built in the stately Georgian revival style, it has a storied past, steeped in the sort of glamor and opulence memorialized in "The Great Gatsby."

HOME INVASION, Page A10



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

The \$20 million waterfront mansion known as "Rock Edge" is a historic property in Beverly and overlooks the ocean.

Exodus Inc.

Business takes off for firms helping Americans leave

By Christopher Muther
GLOBE STAFF

PUERTO VALLARTA, Mexico — It's a cloudless, warm morning in this city on the Pacific. The kind of day when most vacationers would be pulling on their swimsuits or planning a stroll along the scenic Malecón, followed by afternoon cocktails.

But a dozen American visitors are instead spending their morning inside, in a conference room, learning how to set up a Mexican bank account, obtain medical care, navigate the real estate market, and get a residency card.

"So you're considering Mexico," said Shasta Townsend, a relocation expert and real estate agent, as she kicked off the orientation from Ex-pats, a company that helps people looking to relocate outside the United States. "But why consider it? Certainly, there's the weather. There's no shoveling of snow. It's a very beautiful country, and it's very diverse, actually. There are very well-established and welcoming expat communities."

And maybe most importantly: It's easy to ob- LEAVING, Page A10

The MBTA announced several changes in summer fares:

Rides to Foxborough for World Cup games will be more costly and those rides for regular commuter rail customers will be less. **B1.**

President Trump threatened a major escalation in the war in the Middle East, including attacking oil facilities and other critical infrastructure in Iran, if negotiations with Tehran fail. **A3.**

Goes out like a soggy lamb



Tuesday: Rain, clouds later. High 61-66, low 48-53.

Wednesday: Evening storm. Weather and comics, **D5-6.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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